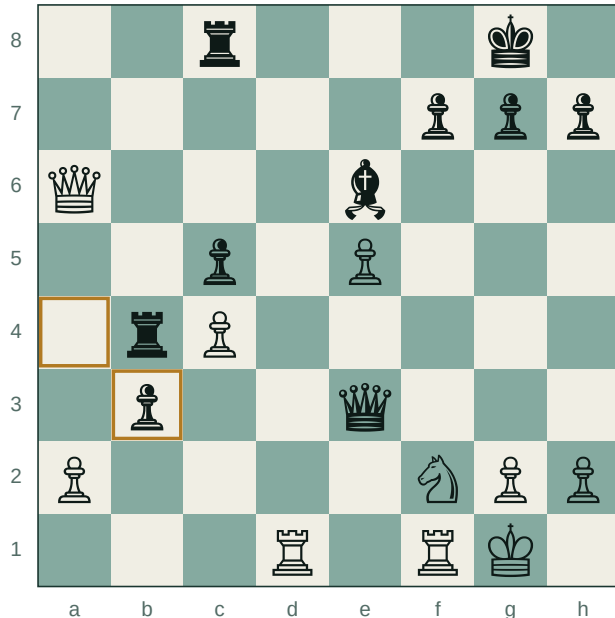


Back-rank mates: White, move 26

Back-rank mates

White to move



Previous move: 25...axb3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26. Qxc8+ Bxc8 27. Rd8#

26.Qxc8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From c8 it attacks king on g8 and bishop on e6. Recorded reply: **26...Bxc8**.

27.Rd8# Mate: rook on d8 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on g8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on d8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A king trapped behind its own pawns may have no flight square when a rook or queen reaches its back rank. The entry square and its defenders are critical.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: queen on e3. Check for tactical protection.